

To live another day: cancer survivors gain strength from trials

Cancer is one of the most life-threatening health conditions, but it can also be a learning and inspiring chapter in someone's life story.

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The year was 2016, and Haryati "Fey" Lawidjaja was at the peak of her career. On a certain day, Fey visited a local hospital in Jakarta with a fever and fatigue and was urged to take a blood test. While waiting for her results, she leisurely walked into the ob-gyn office, which happened to be near the waiting lounge. Unbeknownst to her, it would be the start of the biggest battle in her life.

"They told me it was polyp [at first] and scheduled me for surgery," she said. The scheduled date came, and she was put under anesthetic as her surgery started. The next time she opened her eyes, however, the medical team would surprise her with the news that the surgery had been aborted.

"That's when I knew something was not right," Fey said. "I was only 38 years old, and they told me it was a stage 4B cervical cancer with only a 15 to 18 percent chance of survival."

For Laili Dian Pangestuti, a 43-years old survivor from Banyuwangi, the fateful encounter happened in December 2017. She found a small lump in her breast, and the doctor diagnosed her with a benign tumor. One month later, an open biopsy procedure revealed that she had breast cancer.

"I was supposed to get surgery, but the doctor said I needed to undergo chemotherapy instead because I have triple-negative breast cancer (TNBC) [which has no receptors]," she said.

"Even though I was still in stage 1, [they made sure to explain that] TNBC is a tough one to treat [due to the rapid growth rate]," said Laili, who said that she has no other symptoms. "There was no pain whatsoever, just a small lump the size of a mung bean."

Coping, persevering

More often than not, cancer patients suffer not only physically but also mentally. Laili, who used to work as a nurse, understands that it is essential to keep the patients in a stable mental condition.

"I'm well aware that stress might be one of the factors that can hinder the treatment process. So as soon as I learned about my diagnosis, I immediately left my job to avoid any source of stress and put all of my focus on my treatment," Laili said.

Because she lives in Banyuwangi, she had to take a seven-hour trip by train to Surabaya every time she needed to undergo chemo sessions. The aftermath of those sessions was never a pretty sight.

"One thing that upset me was seeing the effect of the chemo on myself. I need to deal with hair loss, which makes me look like I'm really sick and suffering," she said.

Nevertheless, Laili was determined to make a positive change in her life despite her condition. "I began to spend more time with my children, to exercise, and to practice meditation."

Unlike Laili, who prefers to spend more time with the family when she faces a life-changing problem such as cancer, Fey is the type to isolate herself from the world when she encounters an issue of such magnitude.

"I went to get all my treatments and checkups alone to have my own private space to think," said Fey. "So I don't have to worry too much about what people say."

When Fey learned she had cancer, she was due to run a marathon in Cuba. She had had her itinerary set up, including the 36-hour flight from Jakarta to the island country and back.

"I didn't want to dwell in negative thoughts. No matter how much time I have left, I just want to live my life to the fullest," she said. "The long flight was a

blessing in disguise. It gave me time to think and research. I thought, 'Cancer has been around for so many years, surely there's someone somewhere who knows the cure or the solution.'"

Fey learned about targeted radiotherapy — a type of treatment specifically targeting the protein that controls the survival and growth of cancerous cells. She found an oncology hospital in China that provided such a facility and decided to go there for her treatment.

"I truly rediscovered myself during those times. It was the most intimate time that I had with myself as I got to know myself better. For instance, I never knew I would enjoy cooking," she said.

Between her treatment sessions, Fey started to learn about veganism, raw food, and Ayurvedic recipes. "I learned that cancer is basically acidic, so eating food with alkaline content would do you good."

For Laili, it was a start for her current calling. Laili established a non-profit organization called Komunitas Osing Pink-Yayasan Sahabat Osing Peduli in Banyuwangi. She is currently working with a government institution to raise awareness about cancer, especially cervical and breast cancer, and encourage women to get early cancer detection.

"My days are now mostly filled with assisting cancer patients with their doctor's appointments, giving a consultation session by phone, going for home visits, and educating the public about cancer," Laili said. "Although I'm no longer working professionally, I really enjoy my current role and I'm happy with it."

Cancer awareness in Indonesia

Despite its high mortality rate, cancer awareness in Indonesia is still considerably low, even among cancer patients themselves.

"80 percent of the total breast cancer patients that I assisted had reached an advanced stage because they couldn't detect the cancerous cells earlier," said Laili.

Muhammad Faried Kasaugie, a 33-year-old civil servant from Tangerang, was diagnosed with Hodgkin's Lymphoma, a type of cancer that attacks the lymphatic system and reduces the body's immune system's ability to resist infection, earlier this year.

"I only knew that there was a health condition caused by cancer cells. However, I have no idea about the types of cancer, how to handle it, or what the treatments are at that time."

According to Bob Octavianus, 43, a surgeon at Rumah Sakit Onkologi Surabaya, early cancer detection is still an uncommon thing to do.

"Patients typically become aware of cancer in their bodies when symptoms like pain, discomfort, or little lumps start to arise. These signs show that the cancer cells have been within the patient's body for long enough," Bob said. "In the future, the government is expected to be able to start a screening program to increase the survival rates."

With that said, raising cancer awareness has become a crucial agenda to lower the mortality rate from cancer patients' delayed diagnosis and treatment.

"Some people still view direct discussion about illnesses that affect the female organs as taboo talk," said Laili. "Not all cancer survivors are willing to talk about their experiences, making it quite difficult for the public to access detailed and first-hand information about cancer."

The low awareness level is why cancer activism as such is done by Laili and Fey is important. Fey, who is also a frequent speaker in many cancer-related talks, was encouraged to write an e-book titled *"Masterpiece in the Making"* about her cancer journey after receiving a message from a stranger who said that they were inspired by her story.

"If my story can save people's lives, then I need to share it. For me, life is more than just breathing, it's also about how I learn to grow and contribute to others."